

# THE ATTENTION MERCHANTS

*The Epic Scramble to Get Inside Our Heads*

## Dictionary Definition

**Attention Merchant** (n.)

**1.** An industrial-scale harvester of human attention. **2.** A firm whose business model is the mass capture of attention for resale to advertisers.



BASED ON THE WORK OF TIM WU

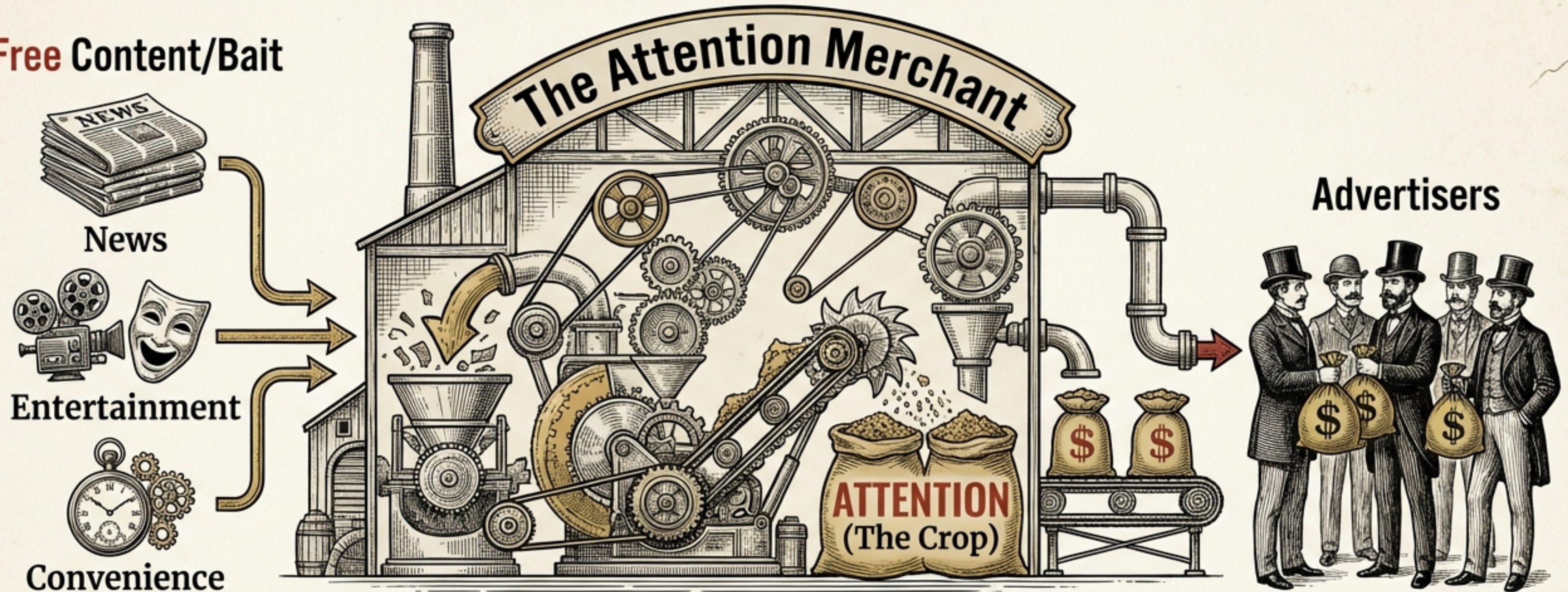






# THE INDUSTRIALIZATION OF HUMAN AWARENESS

Free Content/Bait



Tim Wu argues that attention is a resource, like wheat, pork bellies, or crude oil. It is a crop to be sowed, harvested, and sold. This industry is barely a century old, beginning with the Penny Press in New York and the posters of Paris. It has since colonized every waking moment of our lives.



# THE FIRST MERCHANT: BENJAMIN DAY



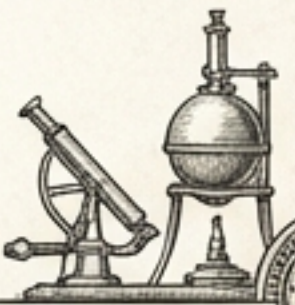
## The Old Model:

- Newspaper Cost: 6¢ 
- Target: The Elite 
- Product: The News 

## The Disruption (1833):

- Newspaper Cost: 1¢ 
- Target: The Masses 
- Product: **YOU** 

Sold at a loss.  
A suicidal  
strategy...  
unless the  
reader was no  
longer the  
customer, but  
the product  
being sold to  
advertisers.





# CAPTURING AUTOMATIC ATTENTION

## The Great Moon Hoax of 1835



### THE NEW YORK SUN

We scientifically denominated them as *Vespertilio-homo*, or man-bat; and they are doubtless innocent and happy creatures.

To capture the masses, Benjamin Day prioritized sensationalism over facts. The “Great Moon Hoax” reported life on the moon discovered by a new telescope. The public knew it might be fake, but they couldn’t look away. Circulation exploded to 19,360—the largest in the world.



# THE INVENTION OF THE TROLL

Enter **James Gordon Bennett** and *The Herald*. He pioneered the monetization of outrage.

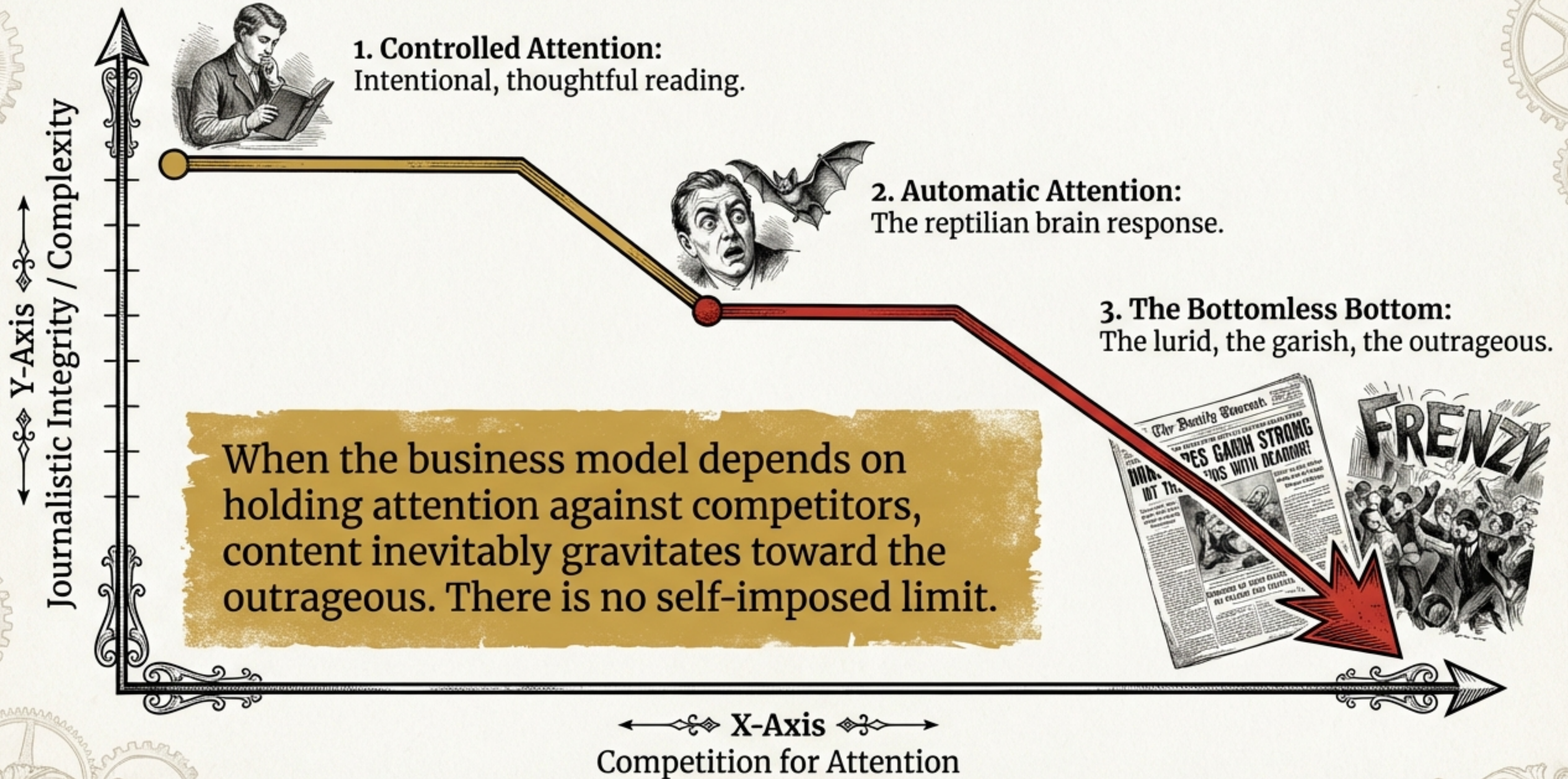
- ⚙️ **Trash Talk:** Called competitors “garbage of society.”
- ⚙️ **True Crime:** Pioneered on-the-scene reporting of violent deaths.
- ⚙️ **Breaking Taboos:** Described a corpse’s “beautiful bust” to titillate readers.

“ To give a correct picture of the world... wherever human nature and real life best displays their freaks and vagaries.” — **James Gordon Bennett** ”



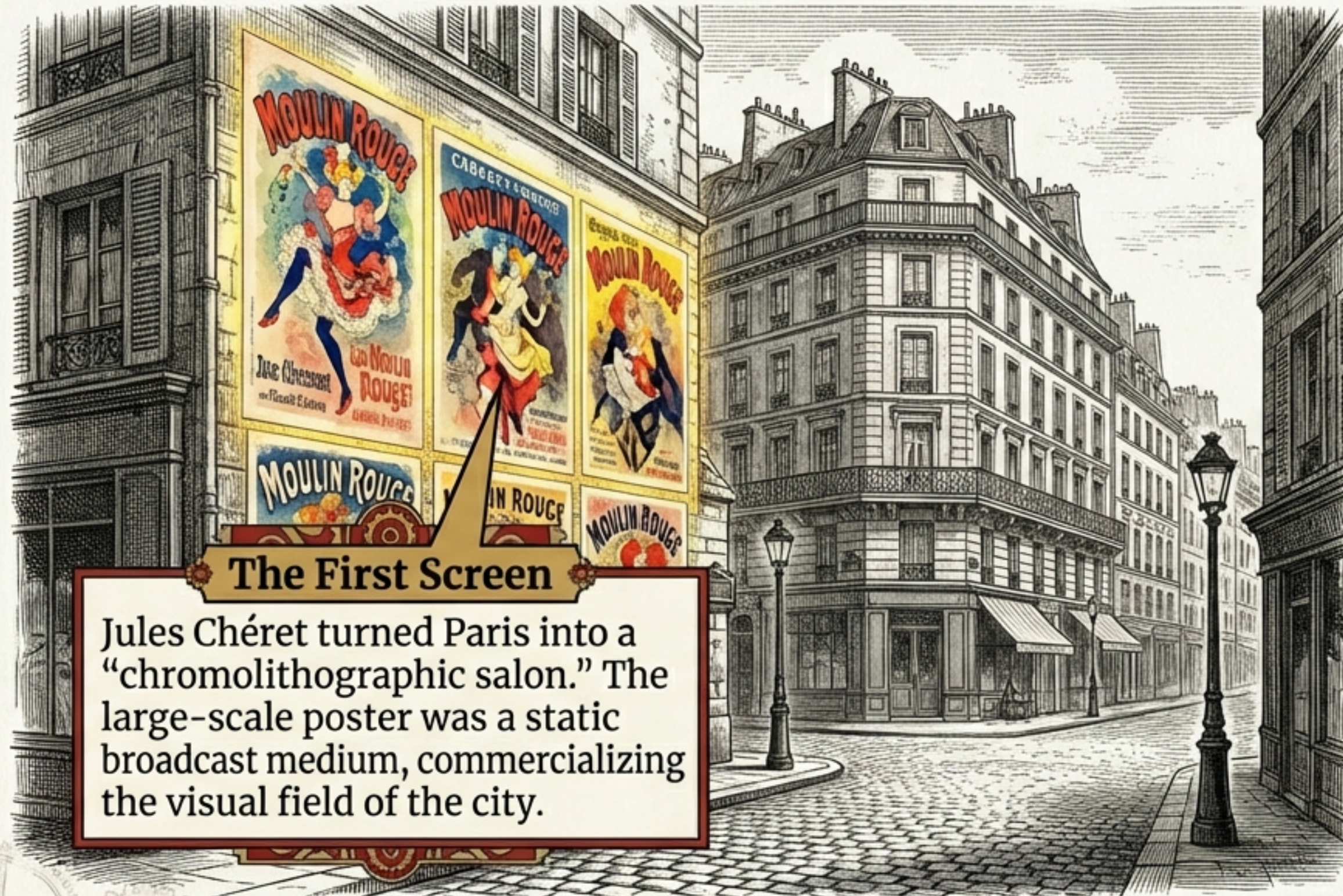


# THE RACE TO THE BOTTOM





# THE CONQUEST OF THE URBAN EYE



## The First Screen

Jules Chéret turned Paris into a “chromolithographic salon.” The large-scale poster was a static broadcast medium, commercializing the visual field of the city.

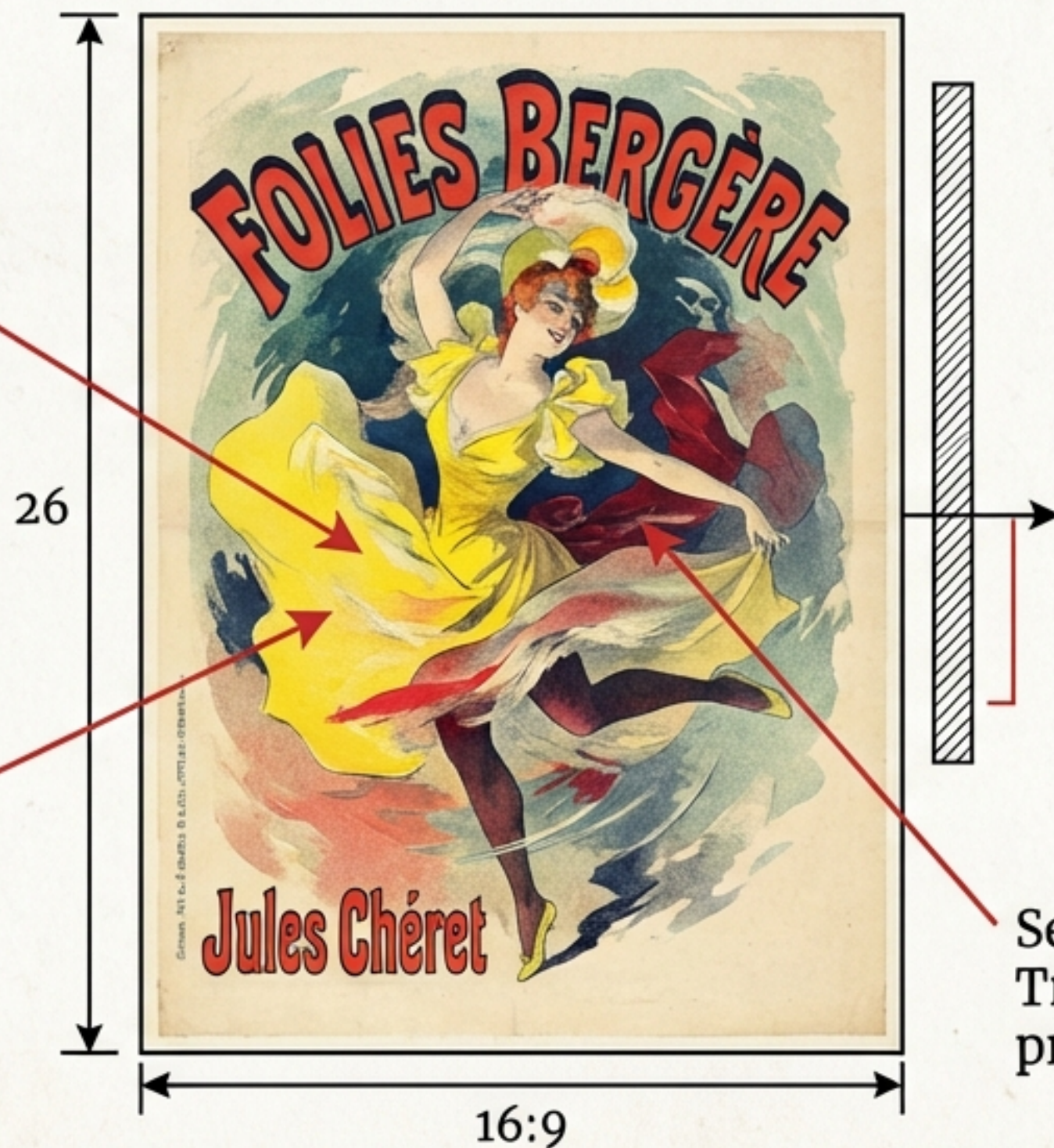
Paris, late 1860s.  
Chéret mastered large-scale lithography, creating posters seven feet high. These were “luminous, brilliant, even blinding” interruptions in the urban landscape.



# HACKING THE FILTER

High Contrast Color:  
Impossible to ignore  
peripherally.

Motion: Captured in  
mid-movement to  
create a flip-book effect.



Sex:  
Triggering  
primal interest.

Humans receive 11  
million bits of  
information per  
second but filter out  
almost all of it.

To break this filter,  
attention merchants  
had to hack the  
brain's ability to  
ignore, targeting the  
'in-between' moments  
of a commute.



# THE ALCHEMIST: TURNING WATER INTO GOLD



Advertising proved it could be a form of alchemy—transforming useless substances into commercial gold through the power of story.

Clark Stanley created demand where none existed.



# THE ARCHITECT OF DESIRE: CLAUDE HOPKINS



**\$100,000,000**

**(Revenue)**

**5,000,000**

**(Free Samples Sent)**

A timid, workaholic former preacher who believed "seemingly every joy in life was a sin." Yet, he became the greatest salesman of his age. He treated advertising as a science: "Advertising must do all." He drove massive revenue for a product that was essentially diluted sulfuric acid.



# THE “REASON-WHY” TECHNIQUE

**Overcoming Skepticism:**  
Anticipating the customer's doubt.

“Some sick one may say:—“But I’ve tried about all medicines . . . Nothing can help me.” Tell him that the physician who compounded this remedy knows better than he.”

**The Secret Ingredient:**  
“Liquid Oxygen”  
(A scientific impossibility, but a marketing goldmine).

“Stop doubting—give Liquozone a test.”

**The Free Sample:**  
“Stop doubting—give Liquozone a test.”

Hopkins created a proposition “no reasonable person could refuse.”  
He industrialized the psychological triggers of trust and hope.



# THE DISENCHANTMENT EFFECT



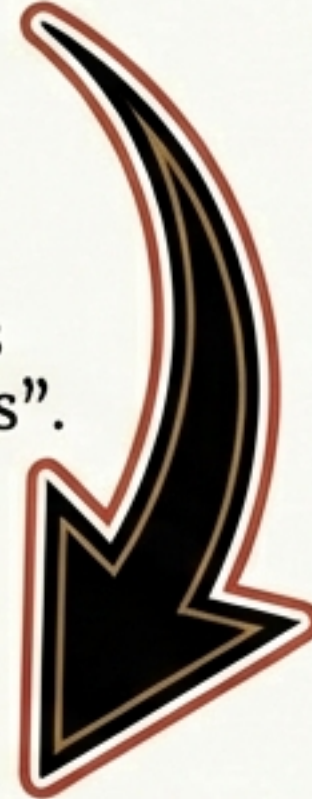
## 1. HARVEST

Discovery of new space/method (Posters, Mail).



## 2. SATURATION

The space is filled. Paris becomes a "wall of posters".



## 3. DISENCHANTMENT

The public desensitizes.  
Triggers fail.



## 4. REVOLT

The public pushes back.



## PARISIAN RESISTANCE:

"Les Amis de Paris" declared war on the "ugly poster," calling it unhygienic and comparing advertising to prostitution.



# THE GREAT AMERICAN FRAUD



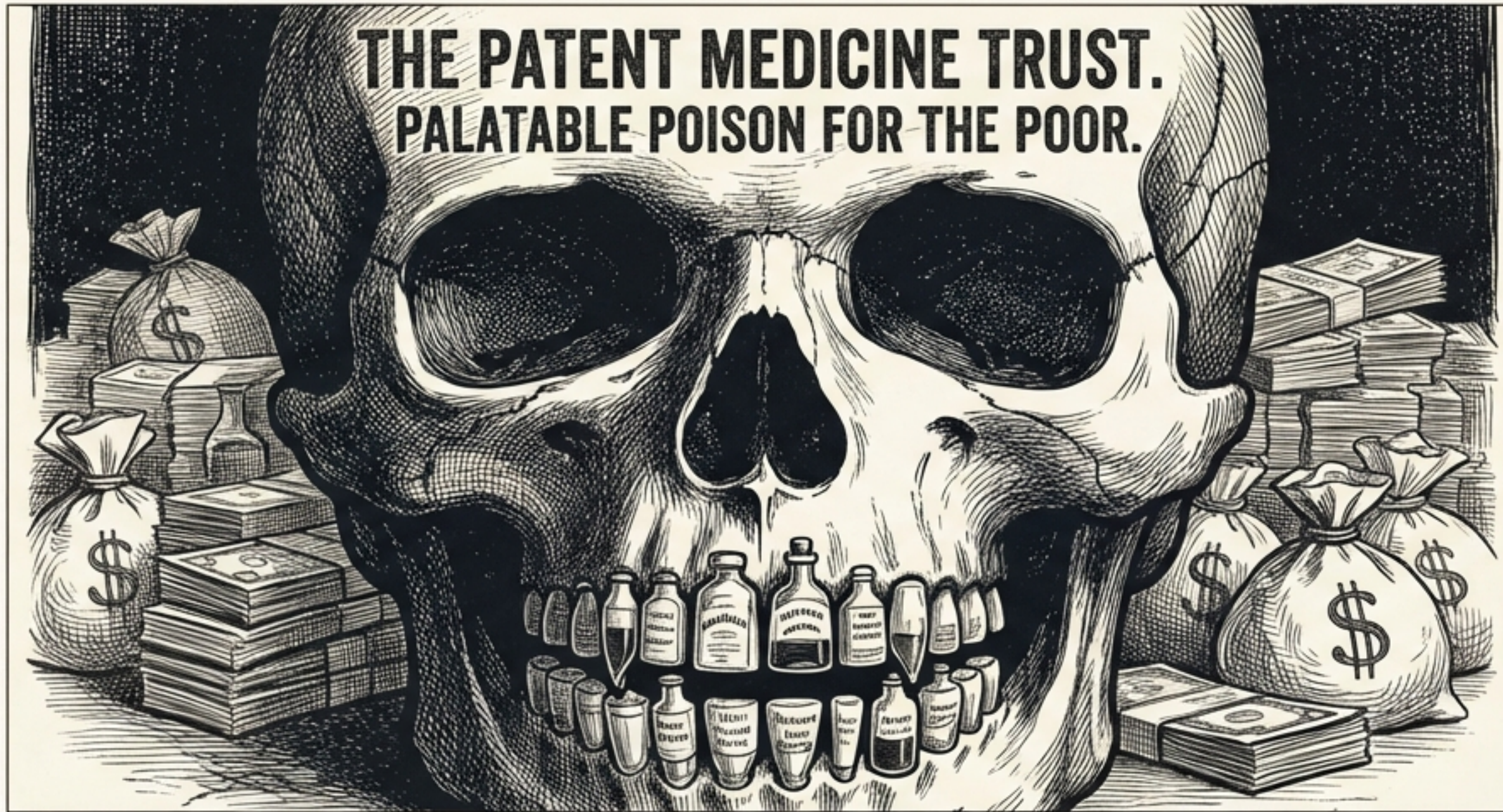
## Collier's Weekly Exposé

### Palatable Poison for the Poor.

The climax of the early attention era. Muckraker Samuel Hopkins Adams investigated the patent medicine industry. He bought the medicines, hired chemists, and exposed the truth: Liquozone was sulfuric acid. Baby syrups contained opium. The 'cures' were killing people.



# “DEATH'S HEAD AT THE FEAST”



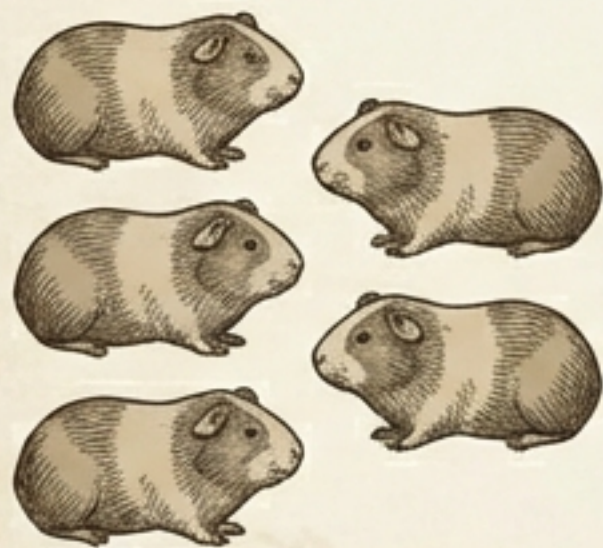
This was not just a news story; it was a counter-advertisement. It used the attention merchants' own tools—striking imagery and fear—against them.



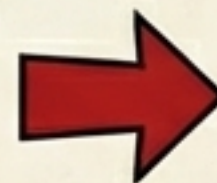
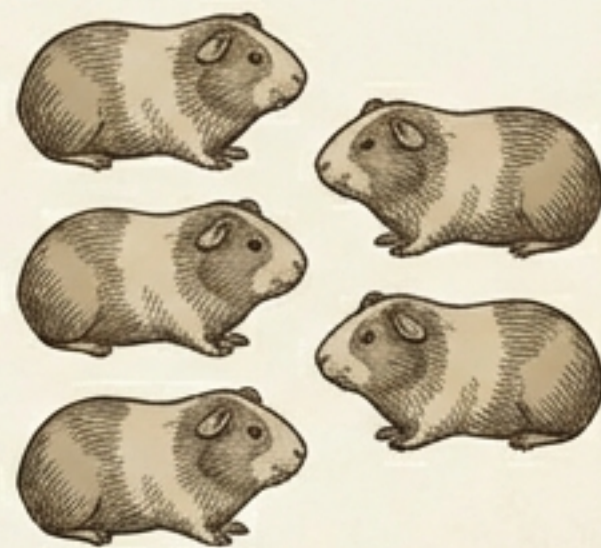
# SCIENCE VS. ALCHEMY

**EXPERIMENT:** Animals infected with Anthrax.

**GROUP A** (Control):



**GROUP B** (Treated with Liquozone):

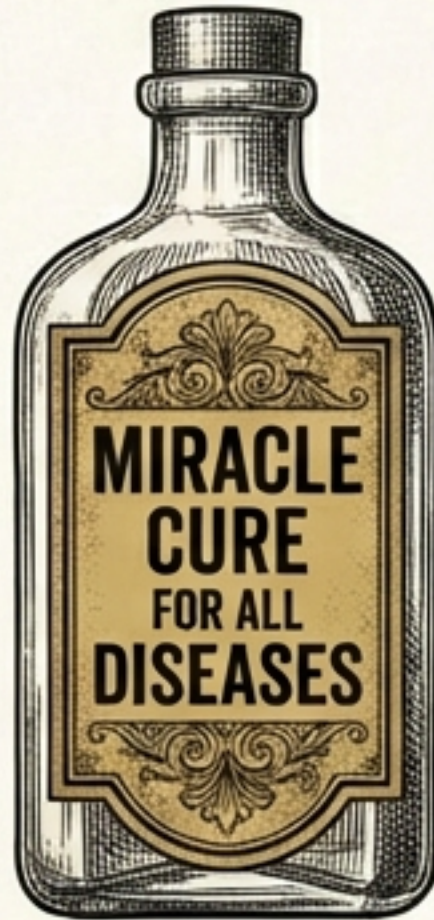


Adams commissioned a lab test. The result proved that Liquozone (sulfuric acid) actually lowered the animals' resistance. The revelation destroyed the brand. Claude Hopkins suffered a nervous breakdown and vowed to leave advertising forever.



# THE IMMUNE RESPONSE: REGULATION

BEFORE



Promises Unverified

**PURE FOOD  
AND DRUG ACT**  
(1906)

**Truth in Labeling.**

AFTER



Truth Revealed

The law criminalized misbranding. The industry collapsed not just because of the law, but because the magic was broken. The astonishing alchemy could never work again.



# THE CYCLE RESETS



1890s



1950s



2000s

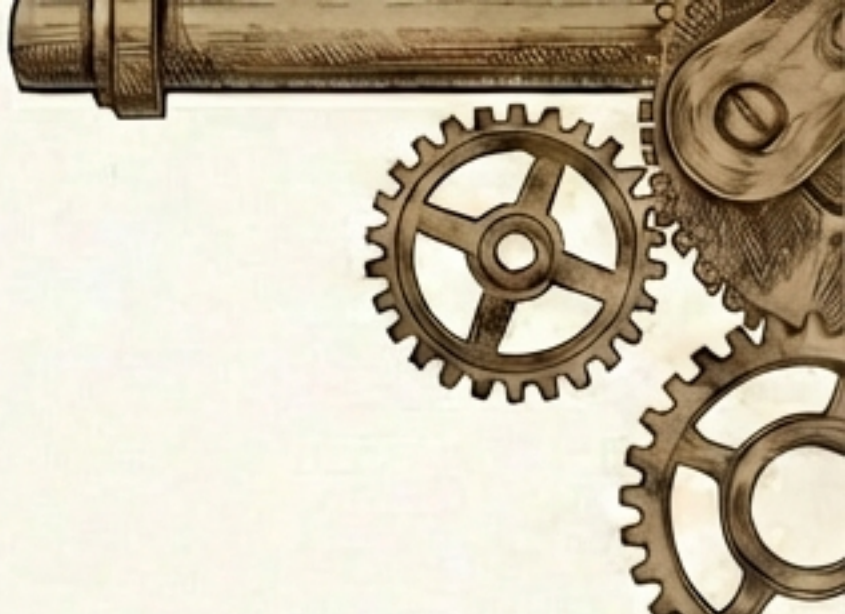


2020s

THE PING

Snake Oil died, but the methods survived. The “Secret Ingredient” became the “Tech Spec.” The “Poster” became the Pop-up. Attention merchants always seek out time and spaces previously walled off, gathering up slivers of un-harvested awareness.





# THE SUM OF OUR LIVES



**“We must reflect that, when we reach the end of our days, our life experience will equal what we have paid attention to, whether whether by choice or default.”**

— William James



The revolt begins with seeing the deal plainly.

